

Cats wary of being undermined

By STEVE WESTON
Citizen Sportswriter

Andy Cohen's main claim to fame is that he runs a beer distributorship in El Paso.

He also coaches baseball at the University of Texas-El Paso. And, somehow, he apparently has found a way to get his players interested in the game this season.

Cohen's Miners merely upset Arizona State University in the opener of Western Athletic Conference Southern Division play last Friday, 7-5, in El Paso (the next day, the Miners were more themselves in double losses to the Sun Devils, 36-10 and 11-5).

Coach Jerry Kindall's University of Arizona Wildcats, 43-2 overall and leaders of the Southern Division at 3-0, get the opportunity tomorrow and Saturday to see just what kind of a team it is that can defeat A-State.

UA, No. 1 in the nation and winner of 19 straight, meets the Miners (1-2) at 3 p.m. tomorrow at Wildcat Field and at 1 p.m. Saturday in a doubleheader at the same site.

Cohen's Miners could be headed for their best season since 1967, when UTEP went 25-12. The Miners are 21-11 and played McNeese College this afternoon. A doubleheader scheduled yesterday was called off because of high winds and blowing dust.

Keying the surprising Miner upsurge is a righthanded pitcher named Roy Stringer, who began the season as an outfielder. He has compiled a 6-0 record, defeated ASU, and will be on the mound tomorrow against the Wildcats.

"The scouts say they are not all that bad," said Kindall. "They've got the kind of ball club that's loose and can rise up and smite you down."

Kindall will counter Stringer tomorrow with the righthander Dave Breuker, who is 10-0 with a 1.67 earned run average.

Cohen will use righthanders Dan Modlinski (3-2) and Jeff Hogan (2-2) Saturday against UA righthanders Joel Godfrey (6-1) and Mark Schimpf (9-0).

Breuker was effective until the late innings in his appearance last weekend as the Cats

swept New Mexico and Godfrey failed in the early innings. Only Schimpf gave a solid performance.

"We'll stay with them," said Kindall. "They appear at the moment to be our top three starters — not necessarily our top three pitchers. Our relevants like Steve Powers and John Roslund are just as high in our estimation. We depend as much on their ability to

come in and shut the door as we do on our starters holding them."

Kindall is nervous about the series with the Miners, who have shown good ability to hit the ball. A .321 team batting average has been posted by UTEP, mainly on third baseman Glenn Villareal's .396, outfielder Joe Pennies' .386 and first baseman Terry Dillingham's .420.

"They can score runs," said Kindall. "They proved that against ASU. They are unpredictable and we must be on guard at every moment."

Kindall made several adjustments against New Mexi-

co's lefthanded pitchers last weekend, mainly using Jim Filippelli in the cleanup spot and Scott Norris in right field.

Against UTEP's righthanders, Kindall will probably go back to Ken Bolek (.333) in right and third baseman Ron Hassey (.463) in the cleanup spot.

Hassey's average and 61 runs batted in is tops on the team, followed by catcher Dennis Haines' .429 and first baseman Marv Thompson's .426.

In other WAC Southern Division play this weekend, New Mexico (9-3) is at ASU (2-1).

UA statistics on page 47

Better than Walton

Fleming best shot

Al Fleming got more than money out of his job last summer in Michigan City, Ind.

He said he gained the maturity that helped get him a share of the all-time season field goal percentage record. In statistics announced today, Fleming's national leading .667 percentage during the past collegiate basketball season put him in a tie with the UCLA's Lew Alcindor's mark in 1967 and Abilene Christian's Kent Martens in 1972.

"I was out on my own for the first time in my life and working in a local factory," recalled the 6-foot-8 University of Arizona sophomore. "And I found out that everywhere you go, everyone doesn't know your name. People there had forgotten what I did in high school basketball. They only were interested in what I was going to do now. You had to prove yourself. You've got to get stronger in order to survive."

Fleming led the country at .722 after 15

games. Then he slumped to .537 his next eight contests and said a combination of the flu and the pressure of leading the nation was a factor.

"The more I thought about it," said the Indiana native, "the worse I played. People would talk about it. I could see the papers and thing 'Heck, I can't do that.'"

But he did, breaking out of the slump to hit 17 of 22 shots in his last three games.

Because of his attitude and because two of the other players who started with Fleming last year as freshmen — Coniel Norman and Eric Money — hope to get hardship exemptions and turn professional, Fleming now sees himself as a leader.

"I can see that this year I was trying to teach Bob Elliot, who's a freshman, and next season if Money and Norman are gone I'll be the old man."

Sports Calendar

TODAY (In Tucson)

PCL baseball: Albuquerque vs. Tucson Toros. 7:30 p.m. Hi Corbett Field.
Dog racing: Tucson Greyhound Park. 8 p.m.

(On radio-TV)

National League baseball: Los Angeles at Atlanta. 4:15 p.m. KFMM-FM (99.5).
American League baseball: Texas at California. 7:40 p.m. KTUC (1400).
Special: Evening with Champions (ice skating). 8 p.m. Channel 6.

TOMORROW (In Tucson)

College baseball: Texas-El Paso at Arizona. 3 p.m. UA Field and KTUC (1400).
PCL baseball: Albuquerque vs. Tucson Toros. 7:30 p.m. Hi Corbett Field.
Dog racing: Tucson Greyhound Park. 8 p.m.

(on Radio-TV)

National League baseball: Los Angeles at Houston. 5:15 p.m. KFMM-FM (99.5).
American League baseball: Chicago at California. 7:40 p.m. KTUC (1400).